

How to Use Your Cost-to-Launch Calculator

SKU ACQ-002 • COST-TO-LAUNCH CALCULATOR

What this workbook does

Forecasts the total cash you need to take a residential property from "I just closed" to "first guest checks in." Closing costs, rehab, furnishings (120-item line-by-line), licensing, photography, listing setup, and the 90-day operating runway. Plus Y1 ROI projection so you know whether the launch dollars come back.

Use this BEFORE you wire your earnest money. Most STR launches go over budget by 30-50% because the buyer didn't have a line-by-line list — they had a guess.

First-time setup (10 min)

1. Open tab **Property Snapshot** — name, address, beds, baths, square footage, target opening date.
2. Tab **Closing Costs** — paste your loan estimate from the lender. The workbook breaks out the deductible vs capitalizable items.
3. Tab **Rehab + Repairs** — line items for any pre-launch fixes: paint, flooring, appliances, plumbing, electrical, exterior. Use your inspection report.
4. Tab **Furnishings (120-item)** — the heart of the workbook. Pre-loaded with a complete furnishing list: bedroom by bedroom, kitchen, bath, living, exterior, technology, supplies. Mark each item Buy / Already Have / Skip and enter cost.
5. Tab **Setup Costs** — STR license / TOT registration, professional photography, listing copy, software subscriptions (PriceLabs, Hostfully, AirDNA), insurance binder.
6. Tab **Operating Runway** — 90 days of fixed costs (mortgage, insurance, utilities, software) reserved against zero bookings.

Reading the outputs

- **Total Cash to Launch:** the sum of all 6 input tabs. This is the money that needs to be in your account at closing.
- **Y1 ROI:** Y1 net income ÷ total cash to launch. Anything 12%+ is solid; under 8% means reconsider the deal.
- **Furnishing density:** total furnishing \$ ÷ square footage. Industry benchmark for 4-star STR: \$25-35/sqft. Lower = under-furnished, higher = over-spent.

Categories to watch

- **Furnishings is where most launches blow the budget.** \$5-15K is the realistic range for a 2-bed, 2-bath. The 120-item list catches everything (toaster, can opener, ice tray) that "I'll just grab one" turns into \$3K of forgotten items.
- **90-day operating runway is non-negotiable.** STR launches take 60-120 days to ramp to stabilized occupancy. Without runway, you panic-list at low rates and tank your search ranking.

At launch

1. Print the Master Cost Summary tab to PDF. Save in your deal folder.
2. Use the Furnishings tab as your shopping list. Check items off as you buy them.
3. After launch, the Y1 Actual column lets you compare projected vs. actual. Use that delta to budget your next acquisition more accurately.

Questions?

hello@thestrledger.com — real humans, fast replies.

Upgrade path: The Acquisition Bundle pairs this with the STR Deal Analyzer (ACQ-001), 5-Year Pro Forma (ACQ-008), and Furniture Setup Budget detailed tool (ACQ-007).